Project Pitch – Machines and the Last Days

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Working title and theme

Machines and the Last Days: How Seventh-day Adventists read AI in the light of the end time (2015–2026)

Seventh-day Adventists have expected Christ's soon return since the 1840s and read current events as fulfilled prophecy. Technology was part of this early on: Uriah Smith and others saw railway and telegraph as fulfilment of Dan 12:4 ("many shall run to and fro, and knowledge shall be increased"). AI is the newest case; a 2026 statement of the church's Biblical Research Institute already rejects scenarios of machine takeover, because God governs history (Dan 2:21). The project asks how the church and its members fit AI into their end-time expectation. As a scholar of religion I am interested in how communities with strong end-time expectations process change, and in how AI can serve such questions with little programming knowledge.

Questions

1. **Readings:** How do Adventist texts link AI to the end time? Which readings dominate: sign of the times (Dan 12:4), tool of mission (Rev 14:6), instrument of persecution (Rev 13), rejection of doom (Dan 2:21), or none?
2. **Change:** Does the response change after ChatGPT (late 2022), and does it follow patterns known from earlier technologies or add something new?
3. **Levels:** Do official statements, periodicals and sermons differ in how apocalyptically they read AI?

Material

- **Church periodicals 2015–2026** (General Conference Archives, PDF): all articles on AI in Adventist Review (church paper), Signs of the Times (outreach, strongly prophetic) and Ministry (for pastors); the number is still to be checked.
- **Official decisions:** the 2026 statement of the Biblical Research Institute, the AI guidelines of the South American Division, relevant General Conference minutes.
- **Pastors and members**, if feasible: a small sample of public sermons and podcasts on AI and prophecy, transcribed locally; affiliation is checked, since many AI prophecy podcasts are evangelical.

Missing voices: The archive is English-language and North American, while most Adventists live in Africa and Latin America. Authors are mostly ordained men; independent ministries and critics are underrepresented.

Approach

1. **Corpus:** Collect the articles, statements and transcripts, and cut them into passages.
2. **Classification:** A model assigns each passage one reading, with a verbatim quote and the source.
3. **RAG:** Questions to the corpus ("How is AI linked to Rev 13?") are answered only from retrieved passages, with citations.
4. **Comparison:** Readings per year and per level (official, periodical, sermon), shown as a simple chart.

Local models (e.g. Qwen, Llama via Ollama) for rights and privacy, at least two compared; a December prototype covers the periodicals.

Why AI, and how it is evaluated

Keyword search finds "artificial intelligence", but not whether a passage reads it as sign, tool or threat; a model can sort the readings and, with RAG, answer questions across all texts with sources. AI can also mislead through invented quotes and imported evangelical readings: for Adventists the mark of the beast concerns Sabbath and Sunday worship, not a microchip as in some evangelical readings.

Evaluation: I assign readings to about 50 passages myself and keep half of them aside as a test set. On these I check how often the model agrees with me and whether its quotes are correct, missed or invented. Five to ten project questions are compared across three stages: plain LLM, designed prompt, RAG.

Who it is for, team, concerns

For: scholars of eschatology, new religious movements and religion and technology; historians of Adventism. **Team:** individual project.

- **Rights:** Recent issues are protected, so the corpus stays local.
- **Ethics:** only published sermons; positions, not persons; lay speakers anonymised; no ridicule of beliefs.

- **Scope and bias:** As a side project it stays small; sermons are dropped if time runs short. Non-eschatological mentions are coded too, as the 2026 statement already argues against apocalyptic readings.